

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- NEU's national executive voted yesterday to call off the 3 October formal strike ballot, after education secretary Lucy Powell confirmed schools can keep — rather than have clawed back — savings from lower employer pension contributions to help fund the 2026-27 pay award.
 → **For your school:** *Worth a short note to staff and governors confirming the strike threat has lifted for now, and flagging that the union still wants the wider pension saving to stay in education.*
- Otherwise a genuinely quiet 24-48 hours: nothing else new broke across SEND, Ofsted, safeguarding, exclusions or local funding beyond the pay/pension story.

NATIONAL PAY & FUNDING

- **NEU calls off the 3 October ballot after the government's pension-savings offer.** The union's national executive met yesterday and voted not to proceed with the formal strike ballot, after Powell wrote to NEU general secretary Daniel Kebede confirming schools can retain local savings from lower employer pension contributions — rather than having them reclaimed centrally — to help meet the 2026-27 pay award. The union says this addresses its 'fully funded' objection, though it wants the full national pension saving, which it puts at £3.3bn, to stay in education too; that total figure is as reported by the union and not independently verified here. ([Tes](#))

→ **For your school:** *Strike risk this term has lifted — worth confirming with your finance lead once written DfE guidance on using the saving is published.*

- **The saving comes from a Local Government Pension Scheme revaluation.** A cut to employer contribution rates freed up roughly £500m across England's schools nationally; DfE says schools can keep it rather than have it clawed back by the Treasury. The pay ballot decision reached earlier this month did not extend to support staff. ([LBC](#))

JARGON-BUSTER - PENSION 'CLAWBACK'

Why yesterday's row was about accounting, not new cash.

When employer pension contribution rates fall, government normally reclaims ('claws back') the saving centrally. This time DfE let schools keep it — turning an accounting change into real money for pay bills.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.